

Sony DSC-P150. These little cameras capable of delivering exceptional photographs are in great demand.

Optical zoom, when coupled with a good CCD sensor, can bring about terrific results. Generally, most mid-range digital cameras provide a 3X or 4X optical zoom feature; however, there are certain cameras that have optical zoom of 10X to 12X—for example, the Panasonic DMC-FZ20. Moreover, to negate the effects of shake, these cameras are provided with optical stabilising systems.

Small LCD viewfinders with better legibility in direct sunlight are gaining popularity in mid-range digital cameras. You may or may not get an EVF (electronic view finder), but it definitely saves quite a lot of battery life.

Batteries are the bane of electronic devices, and no matter how good the battery life of your camera, always bank on an extra pack of batteries. Low-end digital cameras generally require AA-size alkaline batteries, whereas mid-range cameras come with rechargeable batteries and also allow use of standard AA-size cells. High-end digital cameras depend upon custom-designed batteries.

The recent trend amongst manufacturers is to provide number of presets on a camera such as Night shot, Fireworks, Landscape, etc. They help in one-touch configuring of settings.

Trends 2005

The digital camera market leaders are Sony, Kodak, Canon, Olympus, Fuji, HP, and Nikon. As an indicator of who the leaders really are, in Q3 of 2004, shipments of consumer digital cameras in the US were so: Sony was 1 million, closely followed by Kodak at 990,000. Canon did 800,000 shipments, and Olympus was fourth at 585,000.

Consider the US market for a while. When it comes to the growing popularity of digicams, the figures speak for themselves. Sales of digicams in the US in 2004 were 24 million, up from 17 million in 2003. Dollar sales of digicams in the US for in 2004 were \$8 billion, up from \$5.7 billion in 2003. (Source: IDC)

Two-fifths of homes in the US have a digital camera, and this figure will go up to 70 per cent by end of 2007.

You can expect sales figures to go up for quite

a few years to come. Kodak, for example, makes most of its revenue in India through film cameras today, mostly because of prices like Rs 1,000 that basic point-and-shoot cameras are available for. This will change this year as digi-cam penetration grows.

In China, digicam sales were up by 280 per cent in Q2 2004, to 606,000 units. Sales value for Q2 grew 213.2 per cent, to 1.26 billion Yuan (Rs 668 crore) (Source: CCID (China Center of Information Industry Development) Consulting)

Britain is a slightly different story: only 18 per cent of Britons have digital cameras. A total of 12.5 million digicams were sold in the UK last year, compared with 12.1 million film cameras. This means that in Britain, film is only just being shown the way out.

Online Services And Sharing

According to InfoTrends/CAP Ventures, 33 per cent of US households with digital cameras were expected to become members of an online photo service in 2004. Digital photographers primarily use online photo services to share their photos, and an increasing number of consumers are uploading more images to share, print, and store. The forecast reports that online print prices are as much as 50 per cent lower than they were just two years ago.

Photofinishing revenues in the U.S. grew approximately 34 per cent between 2003 and 2004.

On a worldwide basis, revenue is forecasted to increase at a compound annual growth rate of 41 per cent through 2008.

IDC said 28 per cent of digital camera owners share their pictures over the Internet.

The Scene In India

Ashwini Aggarwal, country marketing manager, consumer segment, imaging and printing group, Hewlett-Packard India, says, "The digicam market in India has been growing rapidly. In 2003, we sold 119,000 cameras, and in 2004, the number of units sold was 197,000. In 2005, we plan to sell 325,000 units (pan-India figures).



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